

Global origins



Over million of years, Earth has changed dramatically. Continents have split apart and crashed into each other, and large regions have flooded to create smaller islands. This has had an impact on where animals live today, sometimes leaving close cousins in different parts of the world.

Changing Earth

Earth's outer layer, the crust, is split into tectonic plates, which move very slowly, carrying the land masses with them. Over billions of years, this slow movement has changed Earth's surface beyond recognition. This globe shows how Earth looked 300 million years ago, when the land was joined in two supercontinents called Gondwana and Laurasia.



North and South America more than 2.8 million years ago

Continental collision

Today, North and South America are joined by a narrow strip of land that formed 2.8 million years ago. Before this, animals on each continent were separated. When these two land masses collided, it created a passage for some animals to move across. Some animals from the north, including pumas, traveled south, and some from the south, such as armadillos, ventured north.



Puma



Armadillo

Separated by sea

The Atlantic and Pacific oceans were once connected by a tropical ocean called the Central American Seaway. This body of water separated the continents of North and South America.



Suriname toad